

Recognize it

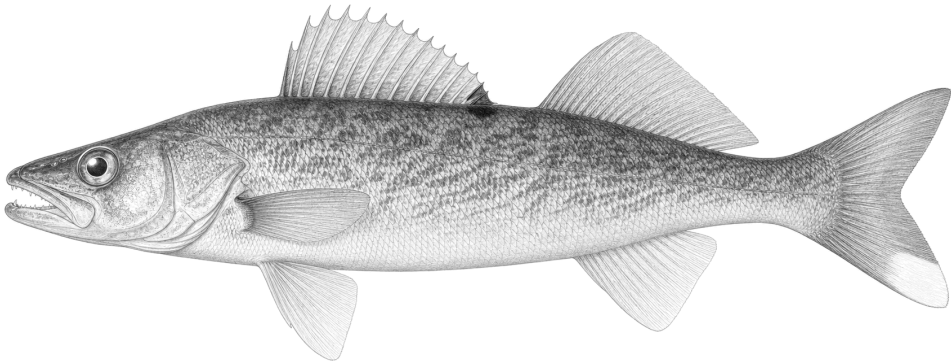
Olive-gold fish with cloudy reflective eye, canine teeth, and white tip on lower tail lobe.

Body	Elongate; separate spiny and soft dorsal fins; dark saddle markings.
Mouth/fins	Large toothed mouth; sharp rear edge on gill cover.
Confusion	Sauger has spots on dorsal fin and no strong white lower-tail tip.

Lake role

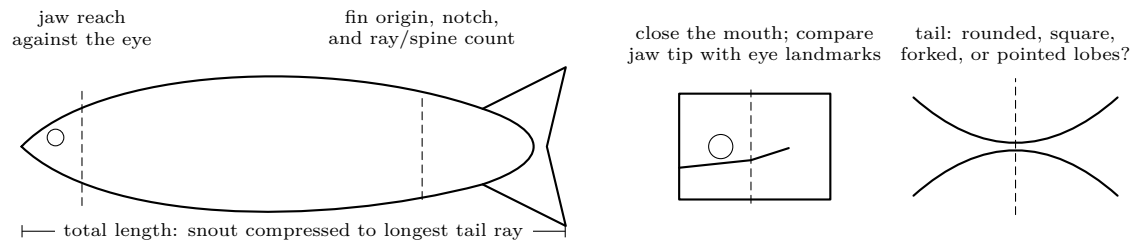
Where it belongs
Hard/soft transitions, points, weed edges, basin prey, and low-light shallows.
Food and season
Fish predator; moves with light, temperature, current, and forage.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



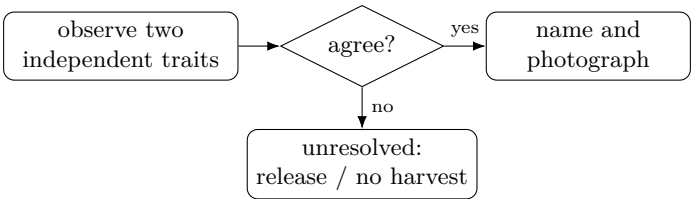
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Confirm the elongate body, two separate dorsal fins, and large canine-toothed mouth.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Inspect the lower tail lobe for a strong white tip and the first dorsal for unspotted membrane.
- 3. **Markings last.** Use the reflective eye and saddles as support, not as the sole decision.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Walleye
Nearest alternative	Sauger has spots on dorsal fin and no strong white lower-tail tip.
Required gate	Walleye requires the white lower-tail tip plus an unspotted first dorsal; otherwise reopen sauger.
Independent check	Photograph tail and erected first dorsal in the same grayscale frame without extending air exposure.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Search deep hard breaks and outside weedline by day; test shallower windward edges in low light.
North	Test narrows/current, weed-to-hard-bottom edges, and evening flats beside depth.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Record light, depth, and bottom transition; one low-light catch does not establish a route.

Presentations

1. **Jig and minnow/plastic.** Use the lightest head that keeps bottom contact without plowing.
2. **Slip rig or float.** Slow live bait along a marked contour or suspend it just above fish.
3. **Stop rule.** No bottom transition, prey, or marks after a controlled pass means move; do not troll memories.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Wet hands, avoid gill cover and dorsal spines, use pliers, and support the fish level.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 18-in minimum; daily bag 3 on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	Choose a legal lower-end fish rather than a large adult; check length-based consumption advice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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